

Disappearing online without breaking the law

Before breakfast, your phone may already have recorded where you slept, which Wi-Fi network you joined, when you woke, how long you looked at a notification and whether you opened a banking, shopping or social-media app. By lunchtime, your IP address, device identifiers, browser characteristics, location clues, payment history and contact graph may have passed through systems run by companies you have never heard of. You may not have typed your full name anywhere. You may still be identifiable.

That is the modern privacy problem. Becoming anonymous online is not about acquiring a magical invisibility cloak – no browser setting, messaging app, VPN or pseudonym can 100% guarantee that. It is about reducing the signals you send unknowingly, separating activities that do not need to be connected, and deciding when a service genuinely needs your real identity.

For Indians, the question is becoming more urgent because digital life is expanding rapidly. At the end of May 2026, India had 1.08 billion broadband subscriptions, including more than 1.01 billion mobile-wireless broadband connections. The country also had 1.277 billion wireless mobile subscriptions. Every connected device can generate location records, account histories, identifiers and behavioural signals.

The threat is not limited to targeted advertisements or embarrassing old posts. India's National Cyber Crime Reporting Portal recorded 2,268,346 incidents in 2024, a 42.08 per cent increase over 2023. Reported losses from cyber fraud rose from ₹2,290.24 crore in 2022 to ₹22,845.73 crore in 2024. That's nearly ten times as much in two years.

The organisations holding our information are struggling too. IBM estimated that the average organisational cost of a data breach in India reached ₹220 million, or ₹22 crore, in 2025 – 13 per cent higher than in 2024. Phishing remained the most common initial attack vector in its India findings. Every unnecessary piece of data collected about you might eventually be leaked, sold, copied, misused or combined with information from elsewhere.

Complete withdrawal is neither realistic nor desirable. Digital payments, navigation, communication, education, entertainment and public services are woven into everyday life. The goal

is not to stop participating. It is to participate without automatically revealing everything.

A bank may be legally required to verify who you are. A telecom provider cannot issue a connection on the basis of an imaginary identity. Government platforms, tax systems and regulated financial services may have legitimate identification requirements. A casual newsletter, gaming forum or discussion group usually does not need the same information. Legal anonymity begins with recognising that difference.

It also requires understanding the line between privacy and deception. Using a pen name is not the same as impersonating another person. Reducing tracking is not permission to commit fraud, threaten someone, evade lawful KYC, forge documents or steal an account. Privacy is a right and a safety practice, it is not immunity from responsibility.

India's data-protection framework is also in transition. A November 2025 government notification brought some provisions of the Digital Personal Data Protection Act into force immediately, while scheduling other groups for one year or 18 months later. Readers will therefore be navigating a system whose major protections and obligations are still being phased in.

The most useful mindset is neither paranoia nor blind trust. It is deliberate disclosure. Ask who needs a piece of information, why they need it, how long they will retain it and what happens if it escapes their control. Consider whether two accounts really need the same phone number, photograph, username or recovery address. Pause before giving an app permanent access to location, contacts, photographs or the microphone merely because it asks.

Perfect anonymity is fragile. One personal login, reused photograph, familiar username, payment trail or revealing background detail can reconnect a supposedly separate identity to you. But failure to achieve perfection is not a reason to surrender.

You may never become completely untraceable. You can, however, become harder to profile casually, harder to dox, harder to scam and more conscious of the digital breadcrumbs you leave behind. Online anonymity, practised legally, is not disappearance. It is the ability to choose when your real identity enters the room. 